The AI Church Toolkit

Use AI for the busy work of ministry. Keep the shepherding yours.

By Tov Rose, C2R Marketing, LLC · $17 one-time · All workflows run on free tiers

Start Here

This guide is for pastors and ministry leaders who carry a full week of ministry work and a short supply of hours. It shows you how to hand the busy work — drafts, agendas, schedules, first passes — to free AI tools, while the work only you can do stays with you.

What this guide is not: it is not a sermon writer, it is not a counselor, and it is not a replacement for your presence with your people. The preaching and the pastoral care are yours. That line does not move anywhere in these ten pages.

How to use this guide

- Read the setup chapter first and set up one free account. Everything else builds on it.
- Each page stands alone. If one task is eating your week, go straight to that page.
- Copy the prompts exactly the first time. Adapt them after you see what comes back.
- Run the safety checklist (near the end of this guide) before anything an AI tool helped draft leaves your desk.

The ground rule

AI assists with preparation and busy work. It does not write the sermon or replace pastoral presence. When a task involves a person's private life, their pain, or their giving, it does not belong in an AI tool at all — the setup chapter lists what never gets pasted in.

Everything here works on free tiers — at the time of writing. Free-tier limits change, so check current limits before use.

Set Up Your Free Accounts

You need one free account to use everything in this guide. The two tools named throughout are ChatGPT and Claude. Both offer free plans, and either one handles every task in these pages. Pick one, learn it well, and do not split your attention across five tools.

Most readers finish setup in about 15 minutes.

Setup checklist

- Go to the tool's own website and create a free account with an email address you check daily.

- Confirm your email and sign in once, so the account is ready when you need it.
- Open a new chat and try one harmless test: ask it to turn three bullet points into a short paragraph.
- Bookmark the page. If your church has a shared computer, sign out when you finish.
- Decide now where drafts will live — one folder for AI-assisted drafts keeps them separate from finished documents.

Never paste this in

- Names of counselees, or anything from a counseling conversation
- Health details, hospital visits, or prayer requests shared with you in confidence
- Giving records, donation amounts, or anything about a family's finances
- Passwords, account numbers, or sign-in details of any kind
- Abuse reports, legal matters, or anything that belongs with your elders, your board, or a lawyer

If a task seems to need any of that information, the task is not an AI task. Do it yourself, or take it to the people responsible for it.

A note on free tiers

Free plans come with limits, and the limits vary by tool and change over time. When you hit a limit, the tool will tell you. Nothing in this guide depends on a paid feature, and if a workflow ever seems to require one, set it aside — there is a free way to do every task here, even if it takes one extra step.

Which tool should you choose?

Either. The prompts in this guide work the same in both, because they rely on clear instructions, not on any special feature. If your church already uses one of them, stay with it. If a fellow leader uses one and can answer your questions, choose that one — a person you can ask is worth more than a small difference between tools. What matters is that you learn one tool's habits: how it phrases things, where it tends to invent, how it handles a long document. That familiarity is what makes the safety checklist quick instead of burdensome.

The 5-Part Prompt

Every prompt in this guide is built the same way, and once you see the pattern you can build your own for any task. A good prompt has five parts: who the tool is helping, the context, the task, the constraints, and the format you want back.

> You are assisting a church leader. CONTEXT: [church size, tradition, audience]. TASK: [what I need]. CONSTRAINTS: plain language; do not invent facts, names, or quotes; flag anything you are unsure of. FORMAT: [list / email / short paragraph]. Do not ask for or use private personal details.

Why each part matters

- **Who:** "Assisting a church leader" sets the tone. The tool writes differently for a church bulletin than for a sales page.
- **Context:** Church size, tradition, and audience change what a good answer looks like. A note for twelve people is not a note for twelve hundred.
- **Task:** One task per prompt. "Help with the newsletter" gets a vague answer; "write a 150-word newsletter item from these announcements" gets a usable one.
- **Constraints:** This is where you protect yourself. "Do not invent facts, names, or quotes" is the single most important sentence in this guide. AI tools will fill gaps with plausible invention if you let them.
- **Format:** Ask for the shape you need — a list, an email draft, a table — so you are editing, not reformatting.

A worked example

Context: a church of about 120, a midweek Bible study. Task: discussion questions. The prompt becomes: "You are assisting a church leader. Context: a church of about 120, midweek adult Bible study. Task: write five discussion questions on the passage we studied this week, Genesis 15. Constraints: plain language; do not invent facts, names, or quotes; flag anything you are unsure of. Format: a numbered list. Do not ask for or use private personal details."

A second example, shorter

The newsletter prompt from the administration chapter, built from the five parts: "You are assisting a church leader. Context: a congregation of about 200, family-oriented. Task: write a 150-word newsletter item from these announcements. Constraints: plain language; use only the facts given; do not invent dates, names, or details. Format: one short paragraph plus a headline." Same skeleton, different task — that is the point of a pattern.

Rewrite it in your own voice

Whatever comes back is a draft, not a finished piece. Read it aloud. If a sentence does not sound like you, change it until it does. Your people know your voice, and they trust it. The tool's

job is to save you the blank page — the words that reach your congregation should be yours.

Sermon Preparation Research, Not Sermon Writing

Let the title of this page be the rule: AI can help you research; it cannot preach. Background questions, study prompts, and lists of things to check — that is the tool's lane. The message itself, formed in prayer and study and preached from your own conviction, is yours.

> I am studying [passage]. List historical and cultural background points a pastor should check. Label each "well established" or "debated." Do not write a sermon.

This prompt does two things well. It asks for background — the world behind the text — and it forces the tool to mark its own confidence. A point labeled "debated" is a point you check twice before it ever reaches a sermon illustration.

> List five questions a first-time visitor might ask about [passage].

Visitors hear your sermon without your years of context. Their questions show you where the passage confuses a modern reader, where it offends, and where it surprises. Preparing answers in advance makes the sermon clearer for everyone, including the people who have sat under it for decades.

> List words in [passage] worth studying, and where I should verify them in a lexicon.

Word studies are where AI output needs the most care. The tool can point you toward words worth a closer look. The closer look happens in a lexicon and in commentaries you trust — never in the chat window.

Verify before you use any of it

- Check every reference and quotation against Scripture itself, in the translation you preach from.
- Check background claims against a trusted commentary before repeating them.
- Treat dates, names, and historical details from an AI tool as unverified until you confirm them elsewhere.
- If the tool states something with confidence and you cannot confirm it, leave it out. Confidence is not evidence.
- Keep your study notes. If you cannot trace where a point came from, do not preach it.

Used this way, the tool is a research assistant that never sleeps and never gets offended when you reject its work. Your study stays yours; the tool just helps you start each question sooner.

Working with a "debated" label

When the tool labels a background point "debated," it is handing you a reading assignment, not an answer. Check how your trusted commentaries handle it. Sometimes the debate is the

interesting part — two honest readings of the same text — and naming it from the pulpit ("scholars read this two ways") teaches your people how to handle Scripture carefully. Sometimes the debate is a sign the point is too uncertain to preach at all. Either way, the decision is a pastor's decision, made with books open.

When the tool invents

Sooner or later the tool will hand you a quotation, a date, or a reference that does not exist. It will look exactly like the real ones. This is the known failure of these tools, and the checklist above is built for it: if you cannot find the quote in the source yourself, it does not go in the sermon — no exceptions, and no "it sounded right." Treat an unverifiable reference as a discarded one, and note the topic so you can study it properly later.

Administration

Administration is where most ministry leaders feel the week leak away: agendas to draft, minutes to write up, newsletter items to produce from a pile of announcements. These are drafting tasks, and drafting is what AI tools do best.

> Turn these bullet notes into a one-page meeting agenda: [notes].

> Turn my notes into draft minutes. Mark anything missing as [CONFIRM].

The [CONFIRM] instruction matters. Minutes become a record people rely on, and a tool that guesses at a missing decision invents a record that never happened. Forcing it to mark the gaps keeps you in charge of what the record says.

> Write a 150-word newsletter item from these announcements: [text].

Give the tool only the announcements themselves — the facts you already have. Then check every date, time, and name in what comes back before it goes anywhere. The tool drafts; you verify. That order never reverses.

One firm boundary

Anything policy- or legal-related goes to your leaders or to counsel — not to an AI tool. Employment questions, discipline matters, property and contract questions, child-safety policies: the tool can format a document, but it must never shape the substance. Draft the announcement of a decision with AI if you like. Make the decision with the people responsible for it.

A simple test for any admin task: if getting it wrong would only cost you an edit, it is an AI task. If getting it wrong would cost someone trust, it is not.

The [CONFIRM] habit, up close

Say your notes from a leaders' meeting say "discussed roof — J. to get quotes." A careless draft

turns that into "The board approved roof repairs." Your prompt's [CONFIRM] instruction forces a better output: "Roof repairs discussed; decision not recorded [CONFIRM]. J. to gather quotes [CONFIRM: deadline]." You confirm two small things in seconds, and the minutes say only what actually happened. Multiply that habit across a year of meetings and your records stay trustworthy — which is the whole value of minutes in the first place.

Bulletins and weekly documents

The same pattern covers the Sunday bulletin: paste the week's announcements and service details you already have, ask for them in bulletin order, and check names and times against your source. Recurring documents are where a saved prompt pays off most — the format settles once, and each week you are only swapping the facts.

Member Care Follow-Up, Safely

Member care is the heart of pastoral work, which is exactly why it needs the firmest boundaries in this guide. The rule is simple: AI may help with templates and reminders. Private care details never enter the tool — no names tied to situations, no health information, no counseling content, ever.

> Draft a short, warm note for a family welcoming a newborn. Leave [NAME] blanks. I will personalize it.
>
> Create a blank weekly care follow-up checklist template with columns for date, contact method, and next step. No personal data.

Notice what both prompts produce: structure without a single private fact. The template comes back empty of everything personal, and everything personal is added by you, by hand, because you are the one who knows these people.

Before any care note goes out

- Send nothing unchanged. A template that goes out word-for-word reads like what it is.
- Add one personal line — something only you would know to say. That line is the note.
- Use no private details in the tool, even "just to make the draft better." Better is not worth it.
- If a follow-up involves illness, loss, or a crisis, write the whole note yourself. Some messages should cost you the time they take.

The checklist template earns its place differently: it keeps follow-up from depending on your memory at the end of a long week. The system remembers the structure; you supply the care. That division — tool holds the pattern, pastor holds the people — is the whole approach of this guide in one page.

Reminders without records

Use the checklist as a rhythm, not a database. A blank template lives in the tool; your actual follow-up list — who you called, who you still owe a visit — lives in your own notebook or planner, the way it always has. At the start of the week, glance at your list, note the next steps in your own words, and let the template prompt you about categories you might forget: the new family from last month, the member who missed two Sundays, the volunteer who carried a heavy load recently. The tool reminds you what kinds of care exist. It never learns who needs it.

Outreach Content

Outreach content is a drafting problem like administration: the events are real, the facts are yours, and what you need is three decent versions of an announcement instead of one written under time pressure at the last minute.

> Write three versions of a social post for [event, date, place]. Warm, not salesy, under 60 words.

Asking for three versions is deliberate. The first version a tool produces is usually the most generic. Choosing between three, and editing the best one, keeps your judgment in the process — and editing a real draft is almost always easier than facing a blank post.

> Draft a "Plan Your Visit" page covering parking, kids' check-in, and service length. Use only the facts I give: [facts].

The sentence "use only the facts I give" does the same work here as "do not invent" does in the 5-part prompt. A visitor page with an invented service time or a wrong check-in detail creates a bad first Sunday. Give the tool your facts, then read what returns against them line by line.

Confirm by hand before anything posts

- Dates, times, and addresses — check every one against the source, character by character.
- Names of people and ministries — spelling comes from you, not from the tool.
- Anything about what a visitor will experience — walk it once in your head as a stranger.

Outreach is an invitation from your church, not content from a machine. The tool helps you say it clearly and say it on time. The welcome itself, like everything else in this guide, stays human.

Walking the "Plan Your Visit" page once

Read the draft the way a nervous first-time guest would. Where do I park — and is that where a guest would actually end up, or where members park out of habit? When do I hand over my children, and to whom? How long is the service, honestly? A page that answers those three things plainly does more for a visitor than any amount of polished language. Ask two members who joined in the last year what they wish they had known; add their answers to your facts list and regenerate the draft. That small loop — real facts in, honest draft out, human check before

it posts — is the entire outreach workflow, and it works for a church of forty or four thousand.

Volunteer Coordination

Volunteers run on clarity and gratitude. People serve gladly when they know exactly what the role asks, when they are needed, and that someone noticed. All three are drafting tasks.

> Write a one-paragraph role description for a [role] volunteer, listing duties and time commitment [fill in].
>
> Build a 4-week rotation for [number] volunteers across [number] slots. Output as a table.
>
> Draft a thank-you note template with [NAME] and [SPECIFIC THING] blanks.

The role description does quiet work for you: a clear paragraph, written once, answers the questions every new volunteer asks, and it sets the time commitment honestly before someone says yes. The rotation table is a first draft — you adjust it for real life, for the volunteer who travels for work and the one who can only serve on the first week of the month. The tool does not know your people. You do.

The thank-you template carries the same rule as the member care chapter: the [SPECIFIC THING] blank is the note. "Thank you for serving" is polite. "Thank you for staying late to stack chairs after the baptism" is gratitude. The tool writes the frame; you write the sentence that makes someone feel seen — because you are the one who saw it.

Adjusting the rotation like a pastor, not a scheduler

The table the tool returns knows nothing about your people, so adjust it with what you know: the nurse who works alternate weekends, the student who disappears during exam weeks, the new volunteer who should shadow someone experienced before serving alone, the faithful one who would never ask for a break and needs you to give her one anyway. Two minutes of that knowledge turns a mechanical grid into a rotation that respects real lives — and a rotation people can actually keep is worth more than a perfect one they quietly abandon.

Using the role description in a real conversation

Do not just post the paragraph. Read it with the person you are asking. "Here is what the role involves, and here is the time it takes — does that fit your season of life?" A clear description makes it safe to say no, and a safe no protects both the volunteer and the ministry. It also makes the yes mean something: they knew what they were accepting, because you wrote it down together — with the tool's help on the wording, and your judgment on everything else.

Keep a small file of these three templates together. The next time a role opens or a rotation turns over, you are editing, not starting over — and consistency across a year of volunteer communication builds a culture where serving feels organized and appreciated.

The Weekly Rhythm and the Safety Checklist

Tools help most when they have a place in the week instead of interrupting it. This rhythm is a suggestion — adapt it to your church's calendar. It makes no promise about hours; it simply gives each kind of task a home.

Monday

- **AI-assisted task:** Sermon research prompts (the research chapter) from the week's passage

Tuesday

- **AI-assisted task:** Agendas and minutes from meeting notes (the administration chapter)

Wednesday

- **AI-assisted task:** Care follow-up checklist review; note templates (the member care chapter)

Thursday

- **AI-assisted task:** Outreach drafts for the weekend (the outreach chapter)

Friday

- **AI-assisted task:** Volunteer rotation check and thank-yous (the volunteers chapter)

Weekend

- **AI-assisted task:** Nothing scheduled — ministry happens in person

The 7-point safety checklist — run it before anything goes out

- 1. Facts verified against the source — dates, times, names, references.
- 2. No private data anywhere in the draft or the prompt that produced it.
- 3. Scripture checked at the source, in the translation you use.
- 4. Rewritten in my voice — it sounds like me, not like a machine.
- 5. Tone fits this church and this moment.
- 6. A leader reviewed anything official before it was sent.
- 7. AI was not used for the preaching itself.

If an item fails, the draft waits. The checklist takes a minute; repairing a wrong fact sent to a whole congregation takes much longer. AI assists with preparation and busy work. It does not write the sermon or replace pastoral presence — the checklist is how that stance becomes a habit instead of a slogan.

Making the checklist stick

Print it and keep it where drafts get finished — above the desk, inside the planner. For the first few weeks, run it out loud, item by item, even when the draft looks clean; the habit forms in the repetitions that feel unnecessary. After a month it becomes the way you read anything the tool touched: facts, privacy, Scripture, voice, tone, review, and the preaching line. Churches run on habits far more than on intentions, and this is the habit this whole guide exists to build.

Quick Reference and Next Steps

Every prompt in this guide

- The 5-Part Prompt — page 3
- Background points to check, labeled "well established" or "debated" — page 4
- Questions a first-time visitor might ask — page 4
- Words worth studying in a lexicon — page 4
- Bullet notes into a meeting agenda — page 5
- Notes into draft minutes, gaps marked [CONFIRM] — page 5
- Announcements into a 150-word newsletter item — page 5
- A warm note for a family welcoming a newborn — page 6
- A blank care follow-up checklist template — page 6
- Three versions of an event post — page 7
- A "Plan Your Visit" page from your facts only — page 7
- A one-paragraph volunteer role description — page 8
- A 4-week volunteer rotation table — page 8
- A thank-you note template with blanks — page 8

Start with one. Pick the task that costs you the most each week, use its prompt once, and run the safety checklist on the result. One workflow that earns your trust is worth more than ten you half-use. Then add a second next week. In a month, the rhythm chapter stops being a suggestion and starts being simply how your week runs — preparation delegated where delegation is safe, and your own time returned to the work only you can do: the preaching, the praying, and the people.

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This guide offers practical suggestions for using AI tools in ministry preparation and administration. It is not legal, financial, medical, or pastoral counsel. You are responsible for verifying anything an AI tool produces before you use it, and for keeping private information about the people you serve out of AI tools.